

the drives. The LG and Samsung drives had trays that appeared a little weaker than those on the other drives, but it's not something the majority would even notice.

The ability of a drive to operate silently is often an indicator of better mechanics and smoother alignment of the various moving components. This in turn means longer life. True to its name, the Asus QuieTrack DRW-1612BL was the quietest of the lot. The other Asus, on the other hand, was the noisiest. It was so noisy we could feel the vibrations through the table on which the PC was placed! The Lite-On SHM-165H6S was also a noisy reader, though hardly as loud as the Asus DRW-1608P2.

Bundled Goodies

A DVD-Writer is more expensive than a Combo drive, so we'd hoped that all the companies would bundle a data cable. However, only the Asus DRW-1608P2, Samsung, and Sony writers came with a data cable.

Bundling media with drives was fashionable until last year, but this time things were different. Only the Lite-On Super AllWrite LH-20A1P came with two DVD-R and a DVD-R DL. The Lite-On LightScribe SHM-165H6S was sent with a LightScribe CD, while the Asus QuieTrack DRW-1612BL came with two. LightScribe media is scarce, like we said, and bundling one such disc allows you to form your first impressions about this technology—until you can get it in stores.

All the drives came with a burning software and a software DVD player. A large proportion of the drives was bundled with Nero 6 OEM. Samsung bundled Nero 6, while the Lite-On Super AllWrite LH-20A1P and the Sony provided Nero 7 Essentials. As you might be aware, Nero 6 OEM does not come with Showtime, the DVD playing software, which is a part of Nero 6 and Nero 7 Essentials. So the drives with Nero 6 OEM were bundled with CyberLink PowerDVD 6, with Asus bundling ASUSDVD (an OEM branded version of PowerDVD). Asus is known for its generous bundle across all its products. It bundled Ulead DVD MovieFactory 4.0 Suite



**Lite-On
Super AllWrite LH-20A1P**
Eminently affordable



SE, which is a premium DVD authoring software and video editor. LG bundled CyberLink PowerProducer, another video editing software.

The bezel determines the looks of the drive, since it is the only part of the drive that is visible when the drive is fitted inside the cabinet. One would want a drive with a bezel colour that matches that of the cabinet exterior. The Lite-On drives came with two bezels—one grey and one black—in addition to the white one on the drive. The Samsung came with an extra black bezel.

PERFORMANCE

Read Performance

The drives that put forth the fastest transfer rates in the DVD part of the Nero CD/DVD speed test were the Lite-On LH-20A1P and the Samsung SH-S182D, while the LG was the slowest of the drives. The LG did not fare well in the CD part of this test either, but it wasn't the lowest scorer here—that place went to the Lite-On SHM-165H6S. This drive was reading OK, but its speed dropped suddenly at the 3.5 GB mark, and it fell to below 4x before climbing back at the 4 GB mark.

Most of these drives were markedly faster and performed well in the SiSoft Sandra test. The Samsung was a low scorer in this test with just a transfer rate of 7 MBps, while the Lite-On LH-20A1P top-scored with 17 MBps. Its access time was also the fastest at just 19 seconds.

The LG ripped the songs off the audio CD in the lowest time of 49.5 seconds, while the rest of the drives (other than the Samsung) took just a few seconds longer. The Samsung took over twice the amount of time—101 seconds to rip.

The DVD ripping test produced mixed results. The Lite-On SHM-165H6S was the fastest, taking just 59.1 seconds, whereas the Asus DRW-1608P2 was the slowest with a excruciatingly slow 388.8 seconds.

Write Performance

None of the drives could recognise the 52x-certified Moser Baer CD-R at the rated speed. We tried another brand of media—Eurovision—but the results were pretty much the same. The Sony

Nero 7 Essentials

Unlike last year, burning software such as Sonic/Roxio Easy Media Creator 8, RecordNow, etc., did not feature at all. We found that all the drive manufacturers have endorsed burning software from Nero (version 6 or 7). Nero 7 Essentials, which is the most feature-rich of the bundled versions, is not just a CD/DVD burning software. Nero Burning ROM—the main burning program—supports a wide range of CD and DVD formats, from regular CD to even Audiobook CD, and DVD-Video, DVD-bootable and DVD-ROM (UDF/ISO). It comes ready with support for newer standards such as Blu-ray. It can even burn LightScribe labels on supported drives.

Overburning is another feature that lets you burn beyond a disc's normal capacity, and this is well-supported here. It also lets you set the Book-Type for maximum compatibility. There are also certain extras such as a music file encoder and ripper.

InCD enables the very convenient drag-and-drop writing a.k.a. packet writing. In this process, you can simply drag and drop data files onto the media instead of using the burning software.

BackItUp allows you to back up your files and folders, or even your entire hard disk.

Still more useful programs are bundled with Nero: Nero Vision is a full-fledged video capture solution that lets you transfer your digital memories to optical media. Be your own DJ with SoundTrax and create the ultimate music mix in this virtual multi-track music studio, and edit tracks using WaveEditor. Use Recode to master your own DVD, or use it to create movies playable on your mobile device.

Cover Designer 2 allows you to design your own covers to adorn the face of a CD or DVD. PhotoSnap is a nice little photo editor that lets you achieve tasks with difficulties ranging from simple to medium. Nero Scout is an indexing service that indexes data on your hard drive and enables access to your files as fast as possible. If you have a CD/DVD image but do not wish to burn it, you can preview it by mounting it on ImageDrive, a virtual drive software.

The drives that came with Nero 7 Essentials did not bundle a DVD playing software because Nero ShowTime comes with it, and is a very capable software DVD player.

Nero 7 Essentials is more than a burning solution. It is a complete multimedia entertainment suite.